

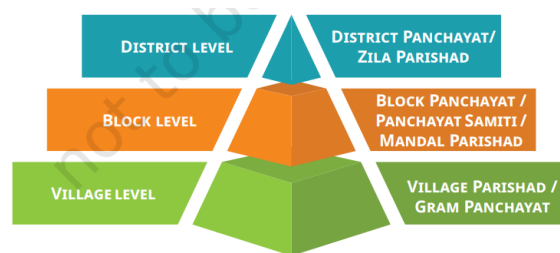
Chapter – 11: Grassroots Democracy – Part 2 – Local Government in Rural Areas

The real India lives in its villages. – M.K. Gandhi

- This chapter – focus – local govt. – rural areas – urban areas – next chapter
- India – enormous size, diversity – 600,000 villages – 8,000 towns – 4,000 cities
- Population – 1.4 billion+ people – 2/3rd – rural areas
- Take a trip – Lakshmanpur – small village – foothills – Himalayas
- 200 houses – population – 700 – most of them – farmers
- People – cultivate lands – rear cows, goats
- Some relatives – in the armed forces – younger villagers – moved to city – search of jobs
- Needs of village – water, main road, primary school
- Villagers – take decisions – BUT – how?
- Where to get resrc. – how to solve dispute – many such questions

Panchayati Raj System

- Like every village – Lakshmanpur – sys. – **local govt.** – Panchayat – village council
- Panchayat – governance comes to people – helps – active participation – decision making
- Panchayat sys. – **Panchayati Raj** – form of **self-govt.**
- Panchayat – vital role – addressing local issues, promoting development, ensuring – benefits – reach people
- Diagram – Panchayati Raj – 3 levels – village, block, district – **3-tier system**
- Together – responsibilities – all aspects of life – agriculture, housing, roads, water resrc., education, health care, cultural activities, etc.



Gram Panchayat

- Gram Panchayat – closest to people – rural areas
- Members – elected directly – Gram Sabha – grp. of adults – enrolled as voters
- Gram Sabha – men, women – discuss matters – their area – take decisions
- Each Gram Sabha – elects a head – Sarpanch (Pradhan)
- Recent yrs. – more and more women – Sarpanchs

Exemplary Sarpanchs

- **Dhyaneshwar Kamble** –
 - Transgender – elected Sarpanch – Tarangfal village, Solapur District, Maharashtra – 2017
 - Motto – *lok seva, gram seva* – service to village – service to public
 - Defeated – 6 other candidates
- **Vandana Bahadur Maida** –
 - Member – Bhil community – Khankhandvi village, Madhya Pradesh – 1st female Sarpanch – her village
 - Convinced women – attend Sabha meetings – address critical issues – education, sanitation

- Her journey – women – play leading role – transform – rural India
- **Popatrao Baguji Pawar –**
 - Hiware Bazar village, Ahmednagar, Maharashtra – freq. droughts – poor yields
 - He became Sarpanch – started applying rainwater harvesting – Anna Hazare’s model
 - Also implemented – watershed conservation – massive tree planting – contributed – recharge groundwater
 - Villagers’ contribution – Hiware Bazar – green and prosperous
 - Shri Popatrao Pawar – Padma Shri – 2020
- Gram Panchayat – assisted by – Panchayat secretary – admin. func. – calling meetings – maintaining records
- Most Gram Panchayats – assisted by – officer – Patwari – maintains villages’ land records
- Some cases – Patwari’s maps – very old

Child Friendly Panchayat Initiative

- Panchayats – listen everybody – even children
- This initiative – creates opportunity – children – express their ideas, opinions
- Steps taken – several States – encourage children participation – Bal Sabhas, Bal Panchayats – regular basis
- Maharashtra – Bal Panchayat – eliminate – child labour
- Members – convince parents – send their wards – school – do not arrange marriage – girls – should be studying
- Several Gram Panchayat – won awards – child-friendly initiative
- Example – west Sikkim –
 - Sangkhu Radhu Khandu Gram Panchayat – lot of imp. – children’s needs, rights
 - Panchayat – built compound walls – safer schools
 - Ensure – hygienic midday meals – built kitchens
 - This Panchayat – declared – child-friendly Gram Panchayat
- Another example – Rajasthan –
 - Children’s Parliament – Bunker Roy’s Barefoot College – few decades ago – helped underprivileged children – rural areas – education – democratic participation
 - Children – 8 to 14 yrs. – governance processes – learn – democracy, social responsibility – night schools, parliament-like elections
 - Parliament – formal procedures – voter ID cards and campaigns
 - Elected representatives – formed cabinet – oversee school management
 - This initiative – helped – leadership skills, social awareness – enable children – challenge – societal norms
 - Children – actively addressed issues – access to education, sanitation, social equality
 - This Parliament – many awards – incl. – World’s Children’s Honorary Award – 2001

Panchayat Samiti and Zila Parishad

- Similar institutions – block level, district level
- Panchayat Samiti – block level – link b/w – Gram Panchayat (village level) and Zila Parishad (district level)

- Members – elected by local people – BUT – may have – other members – Sarpanch, local members – State Legislative Assembly
- Composition – Panchayat Samitis – differ – state to state – BUT – their role – same
- Coordinate matters – across Gram Panchayats –
 - Collecting development plans – all Panchayats – present together – district OR state level
- This helps – allotment of funds – such projects – govt. schemes – Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana – promotes – all-weather roads – rural areas
- All 3 levels – special rule – disadvantaged sections – needs, problems – heard
- These institutions – provision – reserve 1/3rd seats – women
- Structure, func. – Panchayati Raj – differ – across States
- States – authority over institutions – BUT – obj. – same – help villagers – active part – development – their village, local area

- *Arthashastra* – ancient text – governance – written by Kautilya (Chanakya) – 2300 yrs. ago
- Describes – state – structure – economy – made prosperous – duties of ruler – etc.
- Kautilya – expert – statecraft – administrative structure – put in place – village to regional capital
- King – establish –
 - *Sangrahana* – sub-district headquarters – every 10 villages
 - *Karvatika* – district headquarters – every 100 villages
 - *Dronamukha* – every 400 villages
 - *Sthaniya* – provincial headquarters – every 800 villages